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Meet the Next Gen Cheetahs

India's experiment at rebuilding a cheetah landscape is showing positive signs: they are settling down, making babies and going native

By **Rahul Noronha**

SURVIVAL WAS THE ISSUE BACK IN 2022, when India began its grand experiment in bringing the extinct cheetah back to life—by importing from Africa. That's behind us. We have a population boom of sorts, on the back of a breeding project and fresh imports. February 28 saw the latest arrivals at Kuno National Park, from Botswana. Nine cheetahs—six female, three male, all free-ranging, not bred in captivity. They join a burgeoning cheetah demography: 55 individuals, including 33 cubs.

The immigrants flew in in style, from Ghanzi to Gwalior, in a C-17 Globemaster military transport aircraft. Then they hopped over to Kuno in Mi-17 air force choppers, to be released by Union environment minister Bhupender Yadav at the quarantine enclosure at the old Palpur village. A transit house for a few days, till a decision is made on whether they should be released into the wild or shifted to a larger game-stocked enclosure.

So, how has India's Project Cheetah done in the past three and a half years? The Centre gave it full backing. In February 2023, shedding early doubts about viability, it sanctioned visas for another 12 cheetahs from South Africa. Statistically, things have gone reasonably well. A survival rate of 50 per cent is considered good enough for cheetahs, not the hardiest big cat out there even in the African savannah. Of the 20 that came to India in the first and second lots, 11 survive.

But this is India, so the bigger success has been in breeding. The cheetahs have delivered multiple litters and synced their breeding cycles to local weather conditions, which helps survival. By now, the third generation has been born here—cheetahs born in India have bred and produced litters. Of our 55 cheetahs, three are at the Gandhi Sagar sanctuary; the rest are at Kuno, 13 of them free-ranging, including 10 India-born ones.

The foremost task now is to hunt for real estate for future cheetahs. The three at Gandhi Sagar have got a 65 sq. km plot, cordoned off for safety. Another habitat is needed for cheetahs deemed fit to live free. Nauradehi, now designated as a tiger reserve, is being prepped for the purpose with prey base augmentation: spotted deer and black buck from elsewhere.

Besides, an inter-state 'cheetah corridor' is developing organically. In early March, two cheetahs—KP 2 and KP 3—ventured outside Kuno, crossed state borders and travelled 60-70 km into Rajasthan. The radio-collared duo, incidentally brothers, were tracked on either bank of the Parvati river. Long-distance dispersal across landscape boundaries is well-documented cheetah behaviour. The rationale for a proposed 17,000 sq. km inter-state wildlife corridor, spread over seven districts in Rajasthan and eight in MP, is now stronger.

One nagging question: can cheetahs survive in the company of tigers? We will soon know. For starters, Nauradehi has 20-plus tigers. Wildlife managers don't see it as an issue for now. "Historically, not just tigers and cheetahs, even lions have co-existed in India," says divisional forest officer, Nauradehi, Rajneesh Singh, IFS. ■



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DYING FOR SLEEP Jwala rests with her cubs after giving birth in Kuno National Park, Mar. 9

Takeaways

- **India has a total of 55 cheetahs now, including fresh imports and 33 cubs**
- **The 'third generation' has been born. Free-ranging behaviour prompts search for new sanctuaries, and an inter-state cheetah corridor**